

of knowledge, often additional, and sometimes completely new and different. And unless your job is to throw the switch on a toll bridge or to collect tolls on a toll road, your new knowledge is likely to involve a great many things that are uncertain, unknowable, and variable.

Even in “routine” careers, there is still plenty of room for career advancement and moneymaking. But it requires you to step beyond the routine. If you are a schoolteacher, for example, you might have to write a book on education or start a school of your own. If you are a carpenter, you could set up a carpentry business or use your skills to build something rare and interesting enough that it could be sold at high margin or mass produced.

Generally, the more formulaic the work, the less scope there is for making money at it. The more limited—that is to say, the more like school any job is—the less likely you are to turn it into a source of wealth, power, or outsized success.

But assuming you are doing something that is not routine, not formulaic and not limited, what is the secret to making a success of it? Ah, glad you asked. At least part of the secret is sticking to it. Here’s why:

If your work is not simple and not formulaic, you need to use a fair amount of creative thinking, innovation, and entrepreneurship to get ahead. Sometimes your work can be reduced to simple, school-like thinking. More often, it is more complex, involving subtle judgments about people, guesses about how others will react, mastering new technology and leadership skills needed to get others to follow your plan, and so forth. It may involve raising money, “selling” your ideas, taking a chance on a new career or a new business, convincing clients to leave their habitual sources, or convincing employees to work harder—or better.

You may have to develop a new product. Or maybe you have an insight that tells you how to invest your firm’s resources more productively.

Whatever it is, it is likely to require more than your “school brain” to make it happen. It is likely to involve wisdom, intuition, and “people skills.” It is likely to require more of you: your brain, your personality, your heart. And maybe your soul, too.

It is likely to require trusted contacts, seasoned hunches, educated guesses.